Inheritance

Chronicles of the Shadow Vanguard: Vol. 1

By P. David Fox II

1

The Harvest Festival

Sterling Castle, Norfolk, Autumn 1851

The fiddler had been tuning since the chapel bell struck eleven, and by the time Alexander reached the gate he still had not found his A. The note wavered over the yard, went sharp, and sagged back. Nobody minded it except Mr. Fenwick, who was bellowing over it at a cider cart.

"Hold you hard, the lot of you! She's in to the axle. Walk that horse on and you'll have the wheel off and the barrels in the muck, and who'll drink it then?"

The cart had come in over the soft ground by the trough and settled there with the patience of a cow in a gateway. Four estate hands stood about the back of it, considering the problem. Alexander drew off his gloves, put them in his coat pocket, and set his shoulder to the tailboard beside Davies, who anchored the tug-of-war team every autumn and smelled of the tallow he worked into the rope.

Two of the men traded a look over his head. He was taller than either, so the look had to go round him rather than past him, and he gave it no attention whatever.

"On three, Master Alexander, if you please," Davies said.

They heaved on three. The wheel came out of the mire with the sound of a boot leaving a ditch, the barrels knocked together, and Fenwick called the horse something a curate would have had to look up. Alexander stepped back with a dark crescent of the yard on his sleeve and a pleasant ache in his shoulder. Nobody thanked him. He had not expected it, and he found, on examining the matter, that he would have minded if they had.

Across the yard, under the chestnuts where the first yellow had come into the leaves, his father stood at the judging table in his shirtsleeves. Farmer Hodge faced him across it with a marrow cradled in both arms like an infant at the font.

"By weight, your Grace," Hodge said. "Allus has been by weight."

"It has been by weight," Edward agreed, "for the eleven years in which Mrs. Carrow has taken first prize." He laid two scarred fingers on the marrow's flank, as a man might lay them on a horse he meant to buy, and his face settled into the stillness Alexander had watched it hold over the county's tithe returns. "Water weighs a good deal, Mr. Hodge, and costs nothing. I put it to you. What does girth cost?"

Hodge opened his mouth and shut it again. From somewhere behind him, the Widow Carrow announced that she had heard that, thank you.

His mother had placed herself a little way off beside the cake stall, near enough to catch every word and too far for anyone to appeal to her. She caught his eye across the argument and lifted a hand to shade her face, and the thin silver lines across her palm took the sun for an instant before she lowered it. Her lips shaped, without sound, *Help him*. Then, as Edward embarked on the principle of the thing: *Don't.*

He did not. He had never once managed to argue a marrow with the gravity his father gave it, and he suspected this was a failing in him rather than in the marrow. He stood with his hands clasped behind his back, fingertips tapping his thumb in turn, until Thomas Barrow came to stand at his elbow. Barrow wore his good brown coat, far too good for a morning of trestles and hurdles, and there was already straw in the buttonholes.

"Saw you at Fenwick's cart, Master Alexander. He'll tell it after as though he lifted her single-handed, mind."

"He is entirely welcome to."

Barrow smiled at his boots. He watched the judging for a while, and then, in the voice of a man remarking on a change in the wind: "Fen's looking well. Hay's all in, and the eels are running thick below the sluice. That'll feed eleven families this winter, that will, with rents what they are."

"Eleven," Alexander said.

"Counted them myself." Barrow touched his hat and went off to settle an argument over the tug-of-war rope.

Alexander had known Harrow's Fen all his life as a line in the estate book: a long strip of water-meadow under the ridge, let in parcels, which his father would not sell and had never been asked to explain. He looked toward it now. The mist lay over it soft as muslin, and through it, one after another, he found the chimneys. The Davies cottage by the sluice. The Carrows', its whitewash gone grey. He could put a name to nine of them. The other two he would have by Michaelmas, and he was a little ashamed to need until then.

He went in by the scullery passage, which was the quick way to the kitchen and ran past the butler's pantry. Along that stretch he kept his eyes on the copper moulds hung on the opposite wall, fourteen of them, fish and wheatsheaf, and went down the row as he had since boyhood. Had anyone asked, he could not have said what colour the pantry door was painted.

The kitchen met him with a wall of heat and the smell of scalded cream. Mrs. Thompson had festival ribbons looped from the beams among the hams, and was telling a scullery maid to shift herself, love, or else make herself useful. On the great deal table, in a gown of pale green silk that had no business within a mile of a range, sat his sister. She had a tart balanced on her knee and flour up one cuff, and she was swinging her foot.

"Master Alexander." Catherine inclined her head from a seated position with such exactness that it amounted to a curtsey. "You honour our humble hearth, sir. Will you take a tart, or shall I have it carried up on a salver?" She was laughing before she reached the salver. "You've mud all down your arm. Did you push something? Was it Fenwick? Mrs. Thompson says the ribbons stay up till first frost, whatever Mamma says, and I said, well, what if there isn't a frost, what if the winter simply doesn't come this year and we all..."

The sentence stopped. Her gaze had gone past his shoulder to the high window, where there was nothing but the kitchen garden wall and, above it, the pale thread of the road running south between the elms.

"And we all what?" he asked.

"Hm?" She came back to him and held out half the tart. "What was I saying?"

He took it. Behind him Mrs. Thompson dropped a pan lid and called on the Lord, and Catherine was already looking at the glass again.

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Niall had two blunted knives laid out on the bench like a surgeon's instruments before the chapel bell had finished counting two, and did not look up when Alexander came down the yard path, still smelling of trodden straw and cider must, his cravat lost somewhere between the kitchen and here.

"You're late," Niall said.

"You're early. It comes to the same thing." Alexander shrugged out of his coat and rolled his sleeves past the elbow, a habit that did nothing for his aim and everything for his nerve. Six years he had been coming down to this yard of a Saturday. Six years since a boy of sixteen had looked at a bandaged hand across a breakfast table and asked a question he had spent every year since half regretting and never once taking back. *Tomorrow, then,* Niall had said, and tomorrow had gone on arriving.

He picked up the near knife, and Niall's hand came round his wrist before his fingers had finished closing on the grip.

"Higher," Niall said. "You're throwing from the elbow again."

"I'm throwing from wherever my arm happens to be attached."

"That's generally the elbow, aye." He turned the wrist a half-inch, thumb pressed flat along the tendon, and held it there a moment longer than the correction required before he let go, the way he always did, like a man setting down a weight he wasn't yet finished carrying.

Alexander threw. The knife took the chestnut low and wide of the old scar that marked true center, and Niall made the small sound in his throat that meant he had seen it and would say nothing generous about it.

"Easy now, Alex. You're rushing it."

"Again," Alexander said, before the warmth of that could show on his face, and drew the second knife.

A wind was coming up off the stubble fields, worrying at the yew hedge and towing in a rank of cloud from the coast that had not been there an hour before. Alexander turned the blade once for balance, watching Niall rather than the target, which was its own kind of habit. Niall stood the way he always stood, weight forward, ready to be somewhere else at an instant's notice, and his eyes had gone past Alexander's shoulder to the tree line beyond the water-meadow, where nothing at all was happening. It was a small thing. A breath's worth of stillness before he blinked and came back. Alexander had spent six years learning to read it, the way another man learns to read weather in a bank of cloud, and he knew what it meant: that some part of Niall was never quite at ease, never quite here, that the man teaching him to throw a knife was also, always, listening for the sound of one thrown back.

"You're doing it again," Alexander said.

"Doing what."

"Watching the tree line as if it's about to ask you to dance."

"It hasn't asked me yet."

"Is there something out there, or do you simply find a stand of alders better company than me?"

"The alders don't talk back."

"I'm cut to the quick." He let the knife go before he'd finished the sentence, which was cheating and which Niall would tell him so, and it took the chestnut a hand's width from center, closer than the first.

"I'll manage worse before dinner." But something in his mouth had eased, not quite a smile, and his gaze came the rest of the way home to Alexander and stayed there, which was the whole of the answer he was going to get, and, for the moment, enough of one. Alexander did not ask again. He had learned that too, over six years: that Niall's watching was a country with a border he would not be shown across by asking, only by waiting, and the waiting was itself a kind of trust he did not examine too closely for fear of what he would find underneath it.

"Alex! There you are, and both of you filthy, I might have known." Catherine came down the yard path at something between a walk and a run, skirts caught up in one fist and threatening to come loose in the rising wind, and arrived a little out of breath with two small parcels of linen held out like offerings. "I have been sewing all week and nobody has thanked me for it, which I consider a great injustice, so you may both thank me now."

"Thank you," Niall said, gravely, before Alexander could open his mouth, and took the handkerchief she pressed on him with a small bow that made her laugh outright.

Alexander unfolded his. A swallow, worked in blue thread, wings spread as though caught mid-turn, the stitches close and even in a way that told him exactly how many candlelit evenings it had cost her. "For luck," she said, "since neither of you will ever go anywhere to need it, but I thought you ought to have something all the same." She said it lightly, the way she said most things she meant, and her eyes went from Alexander to Niall and back again, once, with nothing in her face he could read and everything in it he half suspected.

"Very touching," he said, to cover the suspecting. "Are you crying, Fraser?"

"Not yet." Niall was already folding the handkerchief into his waistcoat pocket, careful of the stitching, and did not look up.

Catherine only smiled, kissed her brother's cheek, and went back up toward the house with the wind pulling at her skirts and the festival noise rising faintly to meet her. Alexander folded his own handkerchief into his pocket with more attention to the corners than the object strictly required, annoyed with himself and unaccountably pleased, in roughly equal measure, and no more willing to look closely at the second than the first.

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The Price of Useless Land

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